Myanmar does not have a single meaning but rather, it is — to use Gallie's (1956) phrase — an "essentially contested concept". Acknowledging this essentially contested nature of democracy can help make sense of why, especially in aid programmes, there have been such contrasting reactions to the issue of Buddhist–Muslim tension.

Furthermore, I argue that analysis of narratives can illuminate reasons why dialogue about communal violence is so challenging. For some aid workers, universal human rights function as an inviolable foundation that guides discussion about democracy or communal violence. Meanwhile, for many Burmese activists and opposition leaders, notions of unity and protection of the majority are assumed to be necessary foundations for debate. Given the way narratives construct different absolute or inviolable components of democracy, dialogue may not always be progressive and generative of consensus.

This chapter is divided into three sections. I first describe a narrative approach as a way of highlighting the essentially contested nature of the concept of "democracy", shedding light on why there has been such diversity of reactions to communal violence. Next I describe the contrasting ways democratization is commonly narrated within the international donor community, and also among activists in the Burmese democracy movement. Crucially, I highlight that, while Western donor representatives often emphasize *liberal* institution-based democracy and the underlying values of rights and minority protection, in the opposition movement democracy is often described in more personal and *moral* terms with contests over values of unity and majority protection. Finally, I conclude that acknowledgement of these wider narratives can be a step toward increasing the intelligibility of contrasting reactions to Buddhist–Muslim tension in Myanmar.

A NARRATIVE APPROACH

In the last few decades, the idea of narrative has emerged as a popular "portmanteau" (Andrews, Squire and Tamboukou 2008, p. 2) stretching across a range of fields. In this chapter, narrative is taken to mean an account of events related to a political issue that serves to collectively construct a problem and a desired solution (Boswell 2013; Roe 1989). A narrative approach can be valuable in showing how problems and